MIDWESTERN BAPTIST THEOLOGICAL SEMINARY

LEARNING TO LISTEN:
A CONGREGATIONAL CARE CASE STUDY

A RESEARCH PAPER

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BY

MORGAN REED

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ABOUT THIS EXAMPLE

This is a fictional research paper written to demonstrate the `mbtstex` class. The student, congregation, interviews, statistics, secondary sources, and interview quotation are invented. The bibliography illustrates citation formatting; it does not identify research you can consult. The Scripture quotation and references use real biblical passages. A footnote at the first Scripture quotation identifies the English Standard Version as the translation used throughout the paper.

The example includes four heading levels, automatic footnotes, a block quotation, Scripture references, numbered visuals, linked cross-references, appendices, and an automatically sorted bibliography. The source files contain comments at the main formatting decisions. The separate citation gallery demonstrates additional source types that would make this paper considerably longer and its fictional professor considerably less cheerful.

The typeface is TeX Gyre Termes, an explicit draft substitute. For submission, use the class's `submission` option with licensed Times New Roman installed, replace the invented material, and follow the assignment's requirements. This explanatory page and the optional contents and visual lists are included for demonstration. They are not universal course-paper requirements.

CONTENTS

Introduction 1
A Theological Frame for Attentive Care 2
Research Design 3
Illustrative Findings 5
Interpretation and Limits 7
Conclusion 9
APPENDIX A ILLUSTRATIVE INTERVIEW PROTOCOL 10
APPENDIX B COMPLETE ILLUSTRATIVE ACTIVITY RECORD 11
BIBLIOGRAPHY 12

LIST OF TABLES

1 Selected Checkpoints in the Invented Record 5
2 Monthly Activity in the Fictional Congregation 11

LIST OF FIGURES

1 An Illustrative Care Conversation 4

LIST OF GRAPHS

1 Recorded Conversations in Selected Months 6

Introduction

Cedar Grove Church had a welcome team, a care team, and a committee appointed to clarify the relationship between the two. It also had a coffee urn whose operating instructions were better documented than its follow-up procedures. This fictional case study asks how a small congregation might make listening and follow-through more consistent without turning every conversation into a new administrative department.

The argument is modest: a repeatable sequence of attentive conversation, shared reflection, and an agreed next step can give volunteers a useful structure for care. In the invented literature accompanying this example, Anne Mercer distinguishes attentive presence from merely completing a task.[1] Her distinction supplies the working definition used here: a completed conversation creates room for the other person's account before the volunteer proposes an action.[2] The difference matters because a filled form can demonstrate that someone held a pen. It cannot, by itself, demonstrate that someone listened.

The paper develops a theological frame, describes an illustrative training process, and examines invented monthly records and interview excerpts. The numbers show how to report a pattern with appropriate limits; they do not establish that the proposed process would produce the same results elsewhere. Appendix A supplies the interview prompts, and appendix B supplies the full illustrative record.

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[1] Anne Mercer, *The Patient Ministry: Presence and Attention in Congregational Life* (Example City: Fictional Seminary Press, 2022), 24.

[2] Ibid.

A Theological Frame for Attentive Care

Listening Before Answering

James urges his readers to be "quick to hear, slow to speak, slow to anger" (Jas 1:19).[3] For volunteers, the sequence poses a practical question: has the speaker been understood before an answer has been prepared?

Mercer presents attention as an ordinary discipline, while Daniel Vale and Miriam Bell emphasize an explicit next step.[4] These fictional sources frame listening and follow-through as one process. An eloquent promise that no one remembers is still uncompleted, even when it appears in beautifully formatted minutes.

Neighbor Love and Particular Needs

The encounter in Luke 10:25–37 directs attention to a neighbor's concrete situation. Cedar Grove's volunteers therefore ask what help is wanted before recommending a familiar program. A meal, a ride, a later conversation, and no immediate action are distinct possibilities.

Ruth Lin's fictional chapter places hospitality within the routines through which a congregation receives people and remembers their concerns.[5] Here, hospitality names sustained attention rather than an additional event. The calendar already has sufficient events to qualify as a minor work of apocalyptic literature.

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[3] Unless otherwise specified, all Bible references in this paper are to the *English Standard Version* (ESV) (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2025).

[4] Mercer, *Patient Ministry*, 39–41; Daniel Vale and Miriam Bell, *Small Promises, Steady Care: A Congregational Handbook* (Example City: Illustrative Books, 2023), 62.

[5] Ruth Lin, "Hospitality Between Sundays," in *The Ordinary Work of the Church*, ed. Elias Alder (Example City: Fictional Seminary Press, 2021), 87–89.

Research Design

Setting and Participants

The constructed setting consists of forty-eight households and a volunteer team that grows from eight active members in January to twelve in December. Six volunteers participate in the imagined interviews. They are selected to illustrate different experiences of the process, not to represent a statistical sample. No people were recruited, no interviews were conducted, and no congregational records were collected for this example.

The design combines a monthly activity log with brief interviews about how volunteers understand their work. A fictional dissertation by Leah Quill provides the methodological model for reading the two kinds of material together.[6] The log asks what was recorded; the interview asks what the volunteer thought was happening. Agreement between them may be informative, but a discrepancy can be equally useful.

The Three-Step Practice

Figure 1 presents the practice introduced in the hypothetical training. A volunteer first listens without drafting a solution aloud, then reflects back the concern, and finally agrees on an appropriate follow-up. The arrows indicate a usual order rather than a prohibition on returning to an earlier step. If a reflection is mistaken, the next move is to listen again.

[6] Leah Quill, “Listening Practices and Volunteer Formation in Small Congregations” (PhD diss., Fictional Seminary, 2020), 54–58.

FIGURE 1

AN ILLUSTRATIVE CARE CONVERSATION



Source: Author's invented training model.
Note: The listener may return to an earlier step when clarification is needed. The arrows do not represent measured effects.

Practice sessions use ordinary situations: an interrupted conversation, a request that needs clarification, and a promise that must be handed to another volunteer. The team rehearses a brief summary and a specific next step. Ezra Stone's fictional handbook describes a similar exercise in which volunteers distinguish an invitation to help from an assumption that help is wanted.[7]

Recording a Conversation

A record includes the month, whether a conversation was completed, and whether an agreed follow-up was completed during that month. The example uses aggregate counts, so a single household can appear in more than one conversation. These records therefore cannot be interpreted as counts of distinct people served.

What Counts as Follow-Up

A follow-up is counted only when the agreed action occurs. Scheduling a call and making the call are separate events; the schedule alone does not complete the action. The coding guide also distinguishes a newly recorded action from an action carried over from a previous month.[8] This definition is intentionally less generous than the committee's initial proposal to count sincere intentions, which would have produced exceptional results at very little inconvenience.

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[7] Ezra Stone, *Before You Offer a Casserole: Exercises in Listening* (Example City: Illustrative Books, 2023), 73, Kindle.

[8] Cedar Grove Care Team, "Recording Care Conversations," Fictional Cedar Grove Training Resources, December 1, 2025, `https://example.org/cedar-grove/recording-guide`.

Reading the Interviews

The invented interview excerpts are read for three themes: attention, clarification, and follow-through. A response can receive more than one code. The four authors of *Listening in Community* provide the fictional coding vocabulary used in this demonstration.[9] Appendix A includes prompts that invite examples and counterexamples, including occasions when the process was unhelpful.

Illustrative Findings

The Activity Record

Table 1 selects three checkpoints from the full record in table 2. Recorded conversations rise from twelve in January to twenty-seven in June, while the active volunteer count rises from eight to ten. The table reports activity, not the quality of care or the number of distinct households reached. Completed follow-ups may concern conversations from an earlier month.

TABLE 1

SELECTED CHECKPOINTS IN THE INVENTED RECORD

Month	Volunteers	Conversations	Follow-ups
January	8	12	7
April	9	18	11
June	10	27	18

Source: Invented data supplied in appendix B.
Note: Volunteers are active team members; the other columns count completed activities during the month.

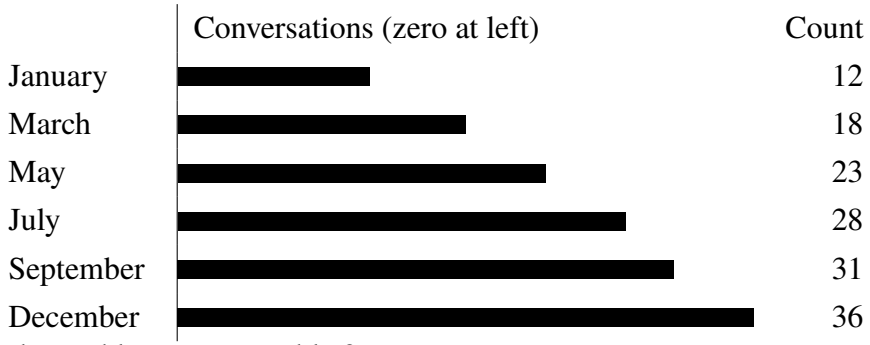
Graph 1 shows selected months across the full year. Its zero baseline and common scale make the numerical increase visible without presenting a small change as a cliff face. December's thirty-six conversations are three times January's twelve. This description is arithmetic, not a claim that the training caused a threefold improvement in ministry.

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[9] Naomi Park et al., *Listening in Community: An Introduction to Qualitative Reflection* (Example City: Fictional Seminary Press, 2022), 112–15.

GRAPH 1

RECORDED CONVERSATIONS IN SELECTED MONTHS



Source: Invented monthly counts in table 2.
Note: Each inch represents twelve conversations. Counts include repeat conversations with the same household.

The intervening months matter because a comparison of only two endpoints can conceal a plateau or a reversal. April's conversation count, for example, matches March's. Nothing in the log explains why. A responsible interpretation leaves that question open rather than assigning the plateau to a spiritual condition that the table was never designed to measure. Noah Wren makes the same distinction between recorded activity and inferred meaning in the fictional article used here.[10]

[10] Noah Wren, "Counting Conversations: Activity Measures and Their Limits," *Journal of Illustrative Ministry Studies* 8, no. 2 (Fall 2024): 49–51.

A Volunteer Describes the Change

The following invented interview excerpt illustrates a shift from rapid problem solving toward clarification. Volunteer June Avery describes an early practice session:

> I arrived with three suggestions and a clipboard. Before the other person finished the first sentence, I had mentally assigned two volunteers and a casserole. When I tried repeating back what I had heard, I discovered that the request was for someone to sit and listen. The clipboard had prepared me for almost everything except that. At the next meeting I wrote down the person's own description before writing an action. We still arranged help, but this time the help answered the question that had actually been asked. The casserole remained available for emergencies.[11]

Avery's account gives the proposed practice a concrete shape: reflection interrupts an assumption and changes the next step. It does not establish that the same change occurred in every conversation. Another invented response describes the steps as awkward at first, especially when a volunteer repeated a summary too mechanically. The case therefore treats the sequence as a guide that requires judgment, not a script to be recited until the other person recognizes the closing prayer.

Interpretation and Limits

What the Pattern Can Support

Within the constructed case, the records and interview excerpt are compatible with a team becoming more deliberate about care. The numeric record supplies a visible pattern, while the excerpt supplies one possible account of a changed habit. Mercer argues in a second fictional book that practical coordination can support a community's stated commitments when responsibility is clear.[12] That argument helps frame a useful interpretation of the case without treating an activity count as a complete description of faithfulness.

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[11] June Avery, Volunteer at Fictional Cedar Grove Church, interview by author, Example City, July 15, 2026.

[12] Anne Mercer, *After the Meeting: Promises, Practices, and the Work of Care* (Example City: Fictional Seminary Press, 2024), 91–94.

The strongest practical proposal is therefore to make the next step visible and reviewable. At a later meeting, a volunteer can ask whether an agreed action occurred and whether it met the expressed need. The team does not need a committee to investigate whether it needs a committee. It needs a shared understanding of who will do what, and an opportunity to correct a mistake.[13]

What the Pattern Cannot Support

Several alternative explanations remain available even within the fictional design. More active volunteers can produce more recorded conversations. Volunteers may become more consistent in recording work they already did. Households may make different requests at different times of year. Without additional evidence, the table cannot separate those possibilities from a change associated with training.[14]

The six interview responses also cannot establish what all households experienced. A volunteer's account of listening well may differ from the other person's account of being heard. A fuller hypothetical study would include those perspectives and actively examine cases that challenge its preferred explanation. Quill's fictional dissertation provides an example of this use of discrepant accounts.[15] In this demonstration, restraint is part of the argument rather than a paragraph added after the enthusiasm has spent the evidence.

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[13] The case distinguishes coordination from the number of meetings held. Compare Mercer, *After the Meeting*, 97; Vale and Bell, *Small Promises*, 66–68. A meeting can produce a useful decision, but its duration is not a unit of pastoral care.

[14] Wren, "Counting Conversations," 56.

[15] Quill, "Listening Practices," 121–24.

Conclusion

This fictional case proposes a small, repeatable practice: listen, reflect, and agree on a next step. The invented record illustrates how a writer can describe activity, connect it to qualitative material, and preserve the distinction between a pattern and an explanation. The theological frame keeps attention on particular neighbors; the procedural frame makes a promise easier to remember and review.

For Cedar Grove, the useful next question would be whether people receiving care recognize the same improvement that volunteers describe. Until that question is examined, a rising graph remains an invitation to inquire. The coffee urn may continue to run on a fixed schedule. Congregational care requires a little more attention.

APPENDIX A

ILLUSTRATIVE INTERVIEW PROTOCOL

These prompts belong to the invented case study. They demonstrate an appendix that supports the discussion without interrupting it. A researcher adapting the example would develop questions appropriate to the actual study.

1. Describe a conversation in which you changed your understanding of what the other person wanted.
2. What did you say or do to check that understanding?
3. Describe an agreed follow-up. How did you know it was complete?
4. When did the three-step practice feel awkward or unhelpful?
5. Describe a conversation that does not fit your overall assessment of the training.
6. What would the other person say about the same encounter?

The imagined interviewer asks for examples before asking for an overall evaluation. The order helps keep a general impression connected to a particular event. Follow-up prompts seek clarification rather than praise for the training. Neither coffee consumption nor the ability to pronounce *hermeneutics* on the first attempt is treated as an outcome measure.

APPENDIX B

COMPLETE ILLUSTRATIVE ACTIVITY RECORD

Table 2 contains all twelve invented monthly observations. Its size makes an appendix the appropriate place for it. Follow-ups can relate to earlier conversations; neither activity column counts unique people.

TABLE 2

MONTHLY ACTIVITY IN THE FICTIONAL CONGREGATION

Month	Volunteers	Conversations	Follow-ups
January	8	12	7
February	8	14	8
March	9	18	10
April	9	18	11
May	10	23	15
June	10	27	18
July	11	28	19
August	11	30	21
September	11	31	23
October	12	32	24
November	12	34	26
December	12	36	28

Source: Author's invented dataset; no actual congregation was studied.
Note: Volunteers are active team members, not new recruits. Conversation and follow-up counts reset each month.

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